

security firm Trend Micro, echoing Clarke. “It is a stable OS, but it’s not a secure OS.”

Clarke has also said that it’s probably *easier* to write a virus for Linux because the code is available.” He has gone on to say that it seems “ridiculous” that users have any doubt about Linux being attacked. “It’s not a target at the moment because the market isn’t there, but LiOn and Ramen (two of the more famous Linux viruses) have already proved that it’s on the menu.”

Then there’s the whole thing about why virus writers write their viruses in the first place. Genes has this to say: “There is some prejudice amongst the virus writing community. If you write a virus for Windows, your peers clap their hands; write one for Linux and they’ll stone you.”

Genes has also said that we are likely to see more viruses capable of denial of service attacks and more network-aware viruses that use techniques similar to those of Code Red and Nimda, two rather infamous viruses. Nimda, as an example, can set up open shares on a network.

The experts agree that what the virus writers will be concentrating on now is social engineering, which, of course, doesn’t depend on the OS.

Grisoft, makers of the AVG anti-virus software, recently warned that it is “only a matter of time” before Linux becomes widely targeted by virus and other malware writers.

Michael Foreman, a partner at AVG UK, said: “In the past few years we have seen the use of enterprise Linux applications growing steadily, and it is only a matter of time before we can expect to see virus attacks specifically targeted at these users.